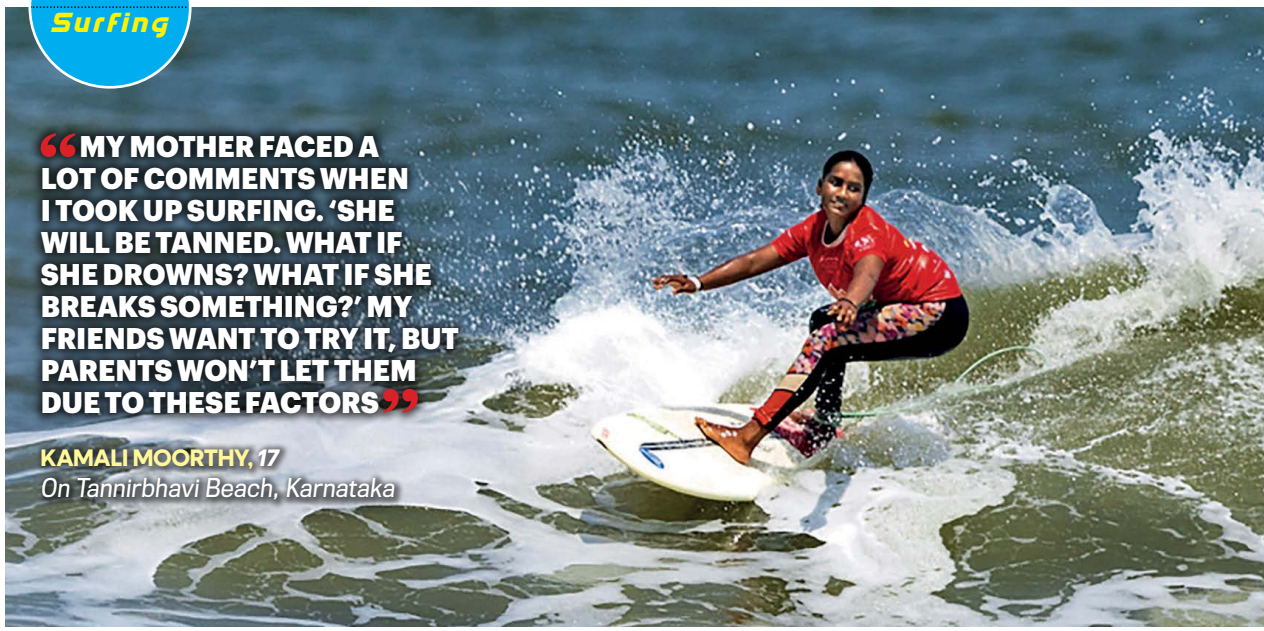


“MY MOTHER FACED A LOT OF COMMENTS WHEN I TOOK UP SURFING. ‘SHE WILL BE TANNED. WHAT IF SHE DROWNS? WHAT IF SHE BREAKS SOMETHING?’ MY FRIENDS WANT TO TRY IT, BUT PARENTS WON’T LET THEM DUE TO THESE FACTORS”

KAMALI MOORTHY, 17
On Tannirbhavi Beach, Karnataka

and slowly read the waves; the ecstasy of gliding on them, if only for a few seconds. Kamali Moorthy, 16, the girl wonder from Mahabalipuram, Tamil Nadu, who made it to the squad and started surfing at age four, is known for her ease in the water and wins both women’s and under-18 competitions. “I trust the ocean,” she says. “If it is supposed to take something from me, I let it because it goes to the ocean.”

PICKING UP THE BOARD

Surfing has been around in India as a competitive sport for only a decade, but Moorthy is part of a growing contingent that is learning to surf the waves with world-class verve. Her cohort is mostly in southern India, yet the SFI is confident that watching Indian surfers compete at the Asian Games could be a game-changer that spreads interest across the country. A medal is instrumental for such a feat—a tall ask, with Japan and Indonesia commanding both a rich history with the sport and better waves for their athletes to train on—but who knows? More and more events are coming up in India— the Andaman Islands saw their first in April. A surfing community all over the coastal country may not be a pipe dream.

Everyone agrees that one man deserves the credit for introducing surfing to India. Jack Hebner, known locally as Surfing Swami, was an American spiritualist who came to India in the 1970s and lived here for over four decades until his demise in 2020. A surfing enthusiast since his teens in Florida, he would take road trips from his ashram near Mysore and in the early 2000s chanced upon Mulki in Karnataka, a coastal town ideal for introducing his disciples to the sport. He started initiating boys to the waves in Mahabalipuram, and set up the Mantra Surf Club in Mulki in 2004.

“INDIAN SURFERS ALREADY HAD TALENT. NOW, WE ARE GIVING THEM EXPOSURE. WE ARE EVEN BEATING SRI LANKA AND THE MALDIVES”

RAMMOHAN PARANJAPE
Vice President, Surfing Federation of India



“In India, nobody was interested in surfing [before Surfing Swami],” says businessman Dhananjay Shetty, chairman of the Surfing Swami Foundation, which supports young kids pursuing surfing in Mulki and Panambur Beach, Karnataka. “Kids in Mulki had not seen the sport before. Swamiji took it to a different level.” Founding members of the Mantra Surf Club would go on to start the Surfing Federation of India in 2011. Today, India’s eastern coast has more surfers and opportunities, according to Ramesh Budihal, 25, who is going to the Asian Games as a reserve. His bronze at the Asian Surfing Championships last year came as a major boost for the sport and served as proof that SFI’s efforts are reaping results. “The scene is a little low in the west,” he says, referring to his own roots in Hubbali, Karnataka. His family now stays in Kovalam, Kerala. “But it’s nice to see more *groms* (juniors, in surfing lexicon) come up,” he adds. Mulki, too, has gained a reputation as the surfing capital of India’s west coast, with surf schools like Aquatic Indica, Mambo Jambo and KayakBoy teaching a new generation at Sasihitlu beach.

Watching surfers paddle away and disappear into the sea only to emerge on their boards is a sight as anxiety-inducing as it is exhilarating. “Catching the wave and riding it is like flying in water,” says 21-year-old Srikanth D., who is also going to the Asian